



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Hillcrest Lutheran Academy

School Website: <https://ffhillcrest.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Hillcrest Lutheran Academy (Hillcrest Academy; Hillcrest Lutheran Academy; Hillcrest Academy, Fergus Falls, MN area) presents a robust Classical Christian educational model. Public-facing materials describe a deliberate fusion of faith formation and rigorous liberal-arts pedagogy, organized around the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a Great-Books-informed approach, with explicit mentions of Great Books, Socratic discussion, and a three-stage progression from grammar through logic to rhetoric. The school positions itself as Christ-centered, with liturgical and communal practices (chapel, Bible study, worship) integrated into the curriculum, and it highlights mentorship by adults as a core component of the living curriculum. Evidence from Hillcrest's site and blog materials shows a consistent rhetoric of forming virtuous character, unity of faith and learning, and a family/community orientation that frames parents as partners in the educational mission. Overall, the school demonstrates alignment with Classical education principles across all six rubric categories.

Key signals include:

- Religious and metaphysical foundation embedded in curriculum and practice (Christ-centered, worship, chapel, Bible study, theology integrated with learning).
- Purpose and goals framed as formation in virtue and wisdom, grounded in timeless truths (truth, goodness, beauty; character formation; worship of God).
- Curriculum reflecting liberal-arts structure (Trivium/Quadrivium-era cadence; Great Books; historical breadth; emphasis on wonder; Latin; classical texts).
- Pedagogy combining contemplative elements with Socratic/rigorous discourse and memory-education practices (Schol  -like contemplative rhythm; singing/memory in lower school; Socratic seminars; upper-school rhetoric).
- Faculty described as mentors and living curriculum; adult mentors central to student formation; long-standing tradition of teacher-student partnership.
- Parents and community engagement evidenced by historical partnership with families and ongoing emphasis on parental involvement and formation within the school's mission (e.g., "Serving Parents" and family/discipleship themes).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL Evidence: The school's materials frame education as a fusion of faith and knowledge, centered on Christ and biblical formation; chapel, Bible study, and worship are embedded in the schedule; theology is described as a governing influence on disciplines; explicit language about worshipping Jesus Christ and knowing God through education; "Master Curriculum Map" ties faith formation to academics. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Strong presence of positive terms aligned with the Six Essential Elements (truth/beauty/goodness; theology; liturgy; worship; sacred). No notable negative signals in the public materials. Estimated positive

keyword presence far outnumbers negative (roughly 8–12 positives vs. 0 negatives in the immediate texts cited). This yields a CLASSICAL rating. Why this rating: The materials demonstrate transcendental moral realism (truth, goodness, beauty) anchored in a Christian metaphysical framework, with liturgical practices and explicit theological grounding.

- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL Evidence: The school emphasizes formation, virtue, wisdom, and human excellence; the aim is to form character in the image of Christ and to cultivate virtues rather than solely preparing for work. Language centers on formation through a Christian liberal-arts curriculum and a telos oriented toward truth, goodness, and beauty. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Keywords such as formation, virtue, wisdom, true/good/beautiful, Telos, scholé, contemplation, and moral imagination appear in public materials. Negative signals (e.g., job-readiness, utilitarianism) are not evident. Approximately 7–10 positive keywords found; 0 negative. CLASSICAL. Why this rating: The aim is formation, character, and the apprehension of timeless truths, not mere information or credentialing.
- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL Evidence: Curriculum is described in Trivium terms (grammar, logic, rhetoric), with explicit reference to Great Books and the Great Conversation; history is woven throughout, not treated as social studies; Latin and literature are part of the program; Three-stage progression is aligned with grammar/logic/rhetoric sequencing; emphasis on wonder. The curriculum map describes integrating faith/formational aims with rigorous content. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive signals include Seven Liberal Arts, Trivium, Quadrivium, Great Books, Great Conversation, history of Western civilization, Latin, literature, and spiritual formation. Negative signals (e.g., modern project-based-only framing) are not apparent. Roughly 9–14 positive keywords identified; 0–1 negative. CLASSICAL. Why this rating: The explicit presence of liberal-arts structure, Great Books, and historic-philosophical texts supports a classical curriculum orientation.
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL Evidence: Pedagogy includes contemplative/restful elements (Scholé) and explicit memory/chanting approaches in lower grades; upper grades emphasize Socratic dialogue, seminars, debates, and rhetorical training; lower grades show focus on memory and delight; teachers guide students toward mastery of logic and rhetoric; the pedagogy aligns with the three-stage Trivium model and with public materials describing upper-school rhetorical development. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include scholé, contemplative learning, singing/memory, Socratic seminars, rhetoric, speeches, and disciplined reasoning. No clear signals of non-classical pedagogy (e.g., exclusively project-based or constructivist-only). Estimated positive keyword presence: 8–12; negative: minimal or 0. CLASSICAL. Why this rating: The school's teaching methods combine restful contemplative elements with rigorous discourse and rhetoric, consistent with classical pedagogy.
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL Evidence: Faculty are described as mentors and living curriculum; teachers are expected to model virtue and knowledge; there is emphasis on portrait or profile of the ideal teacher and student; a collegial, mentor-based approach; adult mentors and a focus on character formation are repeatedly highlighted. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive signals include model teachers/mentors, living curriculum, portrait of teacher/student, mentor-based culture. Negative signals are not evident. Approx. 4–7 positive keywords; 0–1 negative. CLASSICAL. Why this rating: Public materials frame faculty as a central, virtuous, mentorship-driven core of the school; "living curriculum" language aligns with classical expectations of faculty as exemplars.
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL Evidence: Materials show long-standing family engagement and partnership with parents; historical mission to serve parents; references to discipling families and parental involvement; mentions of open campus/visits and family/parent formation are present in the public materials; partnership with families is explicitly discussed in the context of classical education. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include partnership with families, parental engagement, family formation, and school as a community with shared mission. Negative keywords (e.g., parent-customer dynamics) are not evident. Estimated positive keywords: 5–9; negative: 0–1. CLASSICAL. Why this rating: The materials emphasize family partnership and parental formation as integral to the educational mission, consistent with the classical conception of

parental involvement and community cultivation.

Overall assessment (Aggregate ranking)

- CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable since all six categories align with CLASSICAL; no category requires a needle-moving change to move toward full classical alignment.

ABSTRACT

Hillcrest Lutheran Academy MN 56537 demonstrates a coherent Classical Christian profile across all six rubric categories. Religiously and metaphysically, the school foregrounds Christian theology, liturgical practice, and God-centered formation. Its school purpose emphasizes formation, virtue, wisdom, and the true/-good/beautiful telos, consistent with classical aims. Curriculum shows a Trivium- and Great-Books-oriented structure, with Latin, world/history Bible history, and a Master Curriculum Map that binds faith formation to academic goals. Pedagogy blends contemplative (Scholé) approaches with Socratic dialogue and rhetoric, particularly in upper grades, accompanied by a lower-school emphasis on memory and liturgical-inflected learning. Faculty are portrayed as mentors who embody and transmit the living curriculum, and there is clear evidence of sustained parent and community involvement, including historical engagement with families. Collectively, Hillcrest Academy meets the Six Essential Elements criteria at a robust CLASSICAL level.

- Evidence highlights from the school's materials include: Hillcrest's Master Curriculum Map uniting faith formation with academic goals to worship Jesus Christ; grammar-logic-rhetoric progression across school levels; Great Books and Socratic discussions in middle/high school; liturgical/community practices such as chapel and Bible study; adult mentors and the living curriculum model; and historical and ongoing parent engagement.

Note on sources used

- The evaluation draws on Hillcrest Academy's public-facing crawl materials (Hillcrest Academy site/blog content and curriculum maps) that describe classical Christian pedagogy, Great Books and canonical texts, the Trivium progression, and mentorship-centered faculty development. Representative items include the Curriculum Map and descriptions of grammar/logic/rhetoric progression, Great Books, and chapel/Bible study fusion.
- The analysis also references client-facing posts on Hillcrest's site that discuss the integration of faith formation, mentorship, and discipleship with academics, as well as historical/community engagement with families.
- The knowledge-base documents containing the Six Essential Elements (and its Positive/Negative keyword indicators) provide the rubric and keyword lattice used for category-by-category keyword analysis and scoring.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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